

First Principles

Find the truths nothing else rests on, then build up from them alone.

BEST FOR A CHALLENGE, A DECISION, A PROBLEM, A GOAL · ARISTOTLE, FOURTH CENTURY BC · TAKES AN HOUR, DONE PROPERLY

HOW TO RUN IT

1. Describe the situation with enough detail to tell your actual constraints from your assumptions. Say what you know is true and what you believe is true.
2. Surface the assumptions. One sentence each. For each, say where it comes from: convention, imitation, precedent, fear, or an unexamined default. Then judge how much weight it carries: if it were false, would the problem change shape?
3. Strip them away. What remains that is true regardless? Test each candidate three ways: still true if everyone else doing this vanished tomorrow; still true if you had never tried anything before; sayable without "that's how it's done". Aim for three to seven that pass all three.
4. Rebuild from those alone, three ways, as if no prior approach existed. One optimised for speed, one for the biggest long-term result, one for simplicity. For each, write the chain from principle to action.
5. Find the high-leverage move: the one action first principles makes visible that conventional thinking hides. Say why it was hidden, and name the first concrete step.
6. If no single move dominates, write down the runner-up and the trade-off, and choose anyway.

Where it falls down. It is slow, and it is easy to mistake a strongly held belief for a first principle.

WITH A PEN

The situation

What you know is true, and what you believe is true

Phase 1: the assumptions

One sentence each. Where from: convention, imitation, precedent, fear, default. Load-bearing?

Phase 2: what survives

Three tests: true if everyone else vanished / true if you'd never tried / sayable without 'that's how it's done'

A: speed

Chain from principle to action

B: impact

C: simplicity

Phase 4: the high-leverage move

Why conventional thinking hides it. The first concrete step